



It was a high-stakes wager — one wrong move could have cost Gukesh the match. But this time, he was prepared. Having learnt from past mistakes, Gukesh maintained his composure, inducing errors from Wei who faltered, and India clinched a massive victory over its arch-rival.

India then comfortably dispatched Iran, but the unstoppable run met its first obstacle in the Vladimir Kramnik-coached Uzbekistan. The defending champion, impressive as ever, held India to a draw in a tightly-contested match. Arjun had chances against Shamsiddin Vokhidov but couldn't convert, while the rest of the Indian boards were kept in check by the 2022 gold medallist.

Heading into the penultimate round, India held a commanding

two-point lead over second-placed USA, setting up a highly anticipated showdown with its strongest rival. A victory would have all but secured India the gold, but Wesley So had other plans. Playing with the white pieces, So struck the first blow, defeating Praggnanandhaa in an Italian Game. Levon Aronian also piled on the pressure against Vidit, but India's top two boards — Gukesh and Arjun — were smelling blood. **In a repeat of 2022, Gukesh took down World No. 2 Fabiano Caruana, while Arjun outplayed Leinier Dominguez Perez. India secured a stunning victory over the USA, putting it on the brink of history.**

Had the practicality taken charge ahead of the mathematical possibility, India would have secured the gold with a round to spare. But

Stirring effort: Arjun Erigaisi stole the spotlight by claiming individual gold in the Open section. MICHAŁ WALUSZA/FIDE

the final confirmation had to wait as India steamrolled Slovenia in the last round to officially claim its first-ever Chess Olympiad gold.

Double delight

While Gukesh and Arjun led the charge for the men's team, winning eight and nine games respectively to claim individual gold medals, it was Divya Deshmukh and Vantika Agrawal on the bottom two boards of the women's team who did the heavy lifting, ensuring India's double delight in both sections.

The duo accounted for 14 of the team's total 23 wins, earning